2025 Nigeria FinTech Survey Report:

How Young Nigerians Save, Spend, and Use Financial Tools

May 2025

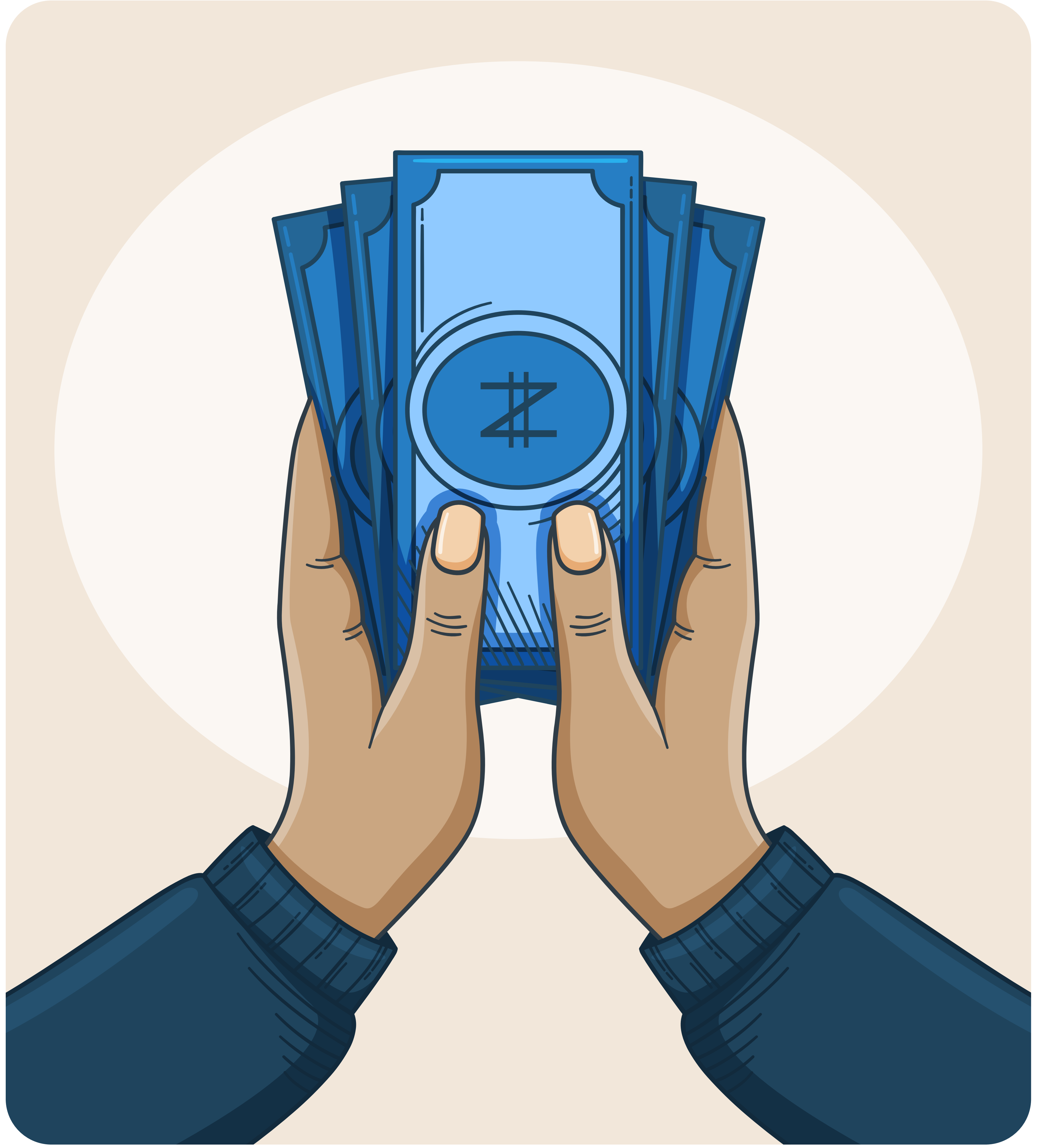
Executive summary

What happens when millions of people want to save—but barely have enough to spend? This report explores how Nigerians save, spend, and manage money—and what that means for businesses, banks, fintechs, and policymakers.

Data was collected in May 2025 through a Meta ad campaign targeting Nigerians aged 18–44, a group that reflects the country's young, mobile-first population. Of the 1,126 respondents, most want to save and plan—but face real barriers: unstable income, rising prices, and limited access to the right tools.

Key findings include:

- Most people save small amounts, often for emergencies or
- specific goals.
- Inflation and high living costs make budgeting difficult, with many people choosing not to track spending at all.
- Essential expenses like food, airtime/data, and transport dominate spending.



- Manual methods (notes, memory) remain common, even as digital tools grow.
- Fintech and bank apps are widely used for storage—but not for planning.
- There's strong interest in tools that automate saving, simplify budgeting, and show all financial activity in one place.
- Most users are open to using multiple financial apps, and expect mobile-first platforms to offer speed, flexibility, and low data usage.
- Open banking and cross-platform partnerships could help meet demand for unified financial views and smarter money management.

This report offers a snapshot of how people are coping and adapting.

It highlights where businesses and institutions can step in—building tools that match people's real habits, and meet them where they are.

Demographics

This section looks at who responded to the survey—from age and gender to where they live and what they do. The patterns reveal which groups are most engaged with digital financial tools—and which voices might still be missing.

Methodology

This report is based on a survey conducted online via Google Forms between May 20–26, 2025. The survey link was distributed through a Meta ad campaign targeting Nigerians aged 18 to 44. To encourage participation, respondents were offered airtime rewards and a chance to win up to ₦50,000 in cash as an incentive. A total of 1,126 valid responses were collected.

The survey focused on how Nigerians save, spend, and manage money. Questions included self-reported behaviors around budgeting, tracking expenses, saving habits, and preferred financial tools. Demographic information such as age, gender, occupation, and state of residence was collected to allow for more detailed analysis.

Simple statistical methods were used to analyze the data, including frequency counts, percentages, and cross-tabulation to compare patterns across groups. We also used chi-square significance testing to examine whether differences in savings behavior across gender and occupation groups were statistically meaningful.

Both tests revealed statistically significant differences—men were more likely to report saving consistently than women (p-value: 0.0106), and employed people saved more often than students or unemployed respondents (p-value: 0.0304).

Limitations

- **Sampling bias**: The survey was distributed online and in English, which likely skewed the sample toward younger, urban, digitally literate respondents across Nigeria.
- **Gender imbalance**: 84% of respondents were male. This affects the ability to generalize findings by gender.
- **Self-reporting**: Responses are based on what people say they do, not on actual transaction data. Social desirability bias and recall errors may affect the accuracy of responses.

- **Age skew**: Nearly all responses came from people aged 18–30, in part due to the ad targeting and Nigeria's young population (median age: 18.1 years old).
- **No weighting**: Results are not weighted to correct for demographic imbalances.
- **Limited statistical modeling**: The analysis used basic descriptive stats and bivariate tests. More advanced modeling (e.g. regressions) was not performed.

Despite these limitations, the survey provides directionally useful insights into how a key demographic—young, mobile-first Nigerians interact with money today.

Gender distribution

The vast majority of respondents were men (84.3%), while only 15.4% were women, and 0.3% chose not to indicate their gender. This gender imbalance likely reflects how the ad performed across different user segments on Meta platforms, and may also be influenced by broader trends in survey participation and internet access.

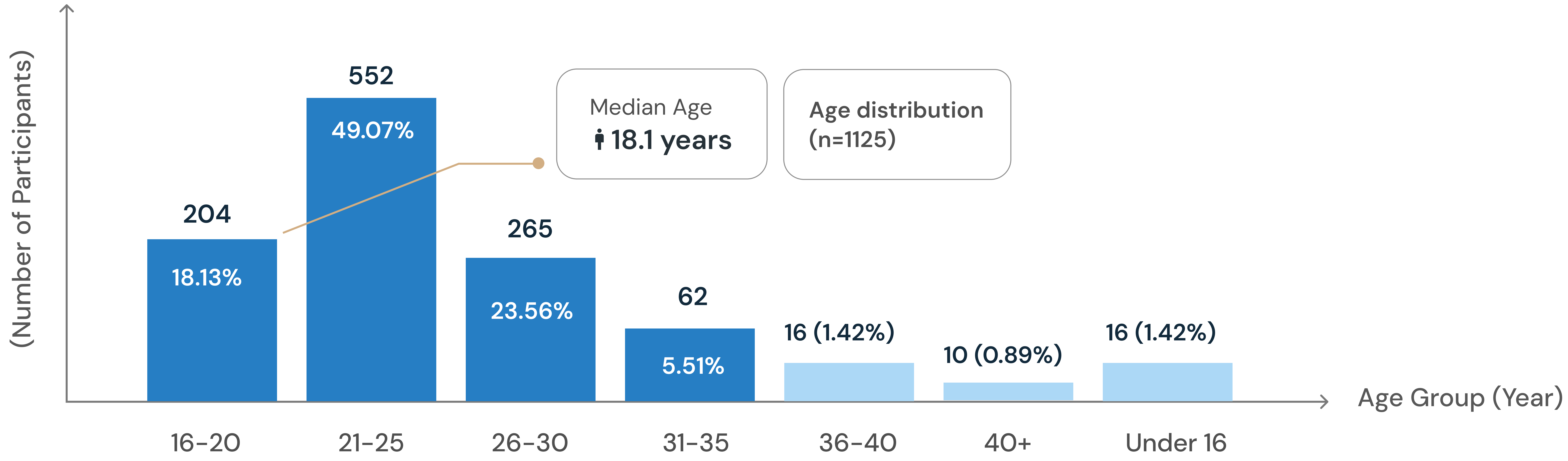
The overrepresentation of men means the results should be read with this bias in mind—especially for questions on financial habits and digital behaviors.

Age distribution

Nearly half the respondents (49.1%) were between 21 and 25 years old. Another 23.5% were aged 26–30, and 18.1% were 16–20. Only 5.5% fell between 30 and 35 years old.

This youthful skew wasn't random—it's the result of deliberate targeting. The survey was promoted to Nigerians aged 18–44 via a Meta ad campaign, and younger people were more likely to respond, given their higher comfort with digital tools and mobile-first platforms. Nigeria's own demographics also play a role here: the median age nationally is just 18.1 years. So even without ad targeting, younger people were more likely to dominate the data.

Age of Distribution of Participants



Occupation

The data is heavily shaped by respondents in early-stage or non-traditional employment. One in three (33.3%) are students, and 20.8% are entrepreneurs. Civil servants account for 10.1%, and the remaining 35.8% include freelancers, tech workers, artisans, job seekers, and homemakers.

This mix reflects a young, digitally connected population—people likely to be navigating flexible income, irregular cash flow, and the early stages of financial independence.

These circumstances should be considered when interpreting responses about saving, budgeting, and financial app usage.

Occupation	Count	Percentage
Student	403	33.28%
Entrepreneur	252	20.81%
Civil servant	122	10.08%
Corp member	78	6.44%
Job seeker	72	5.95%
Private sector	56	4.63%
Tech professional	41	3.39%
Artisan	32	2.64%

Occupation	Count	Percentage
Housewife	26	2.15%
Teacher	24	1.98%
Healthcare worker	19	1.57%
Driver	14	1.16%
Clergy	8	0.66%
Security	6	0.50%
Other	51	4.21%

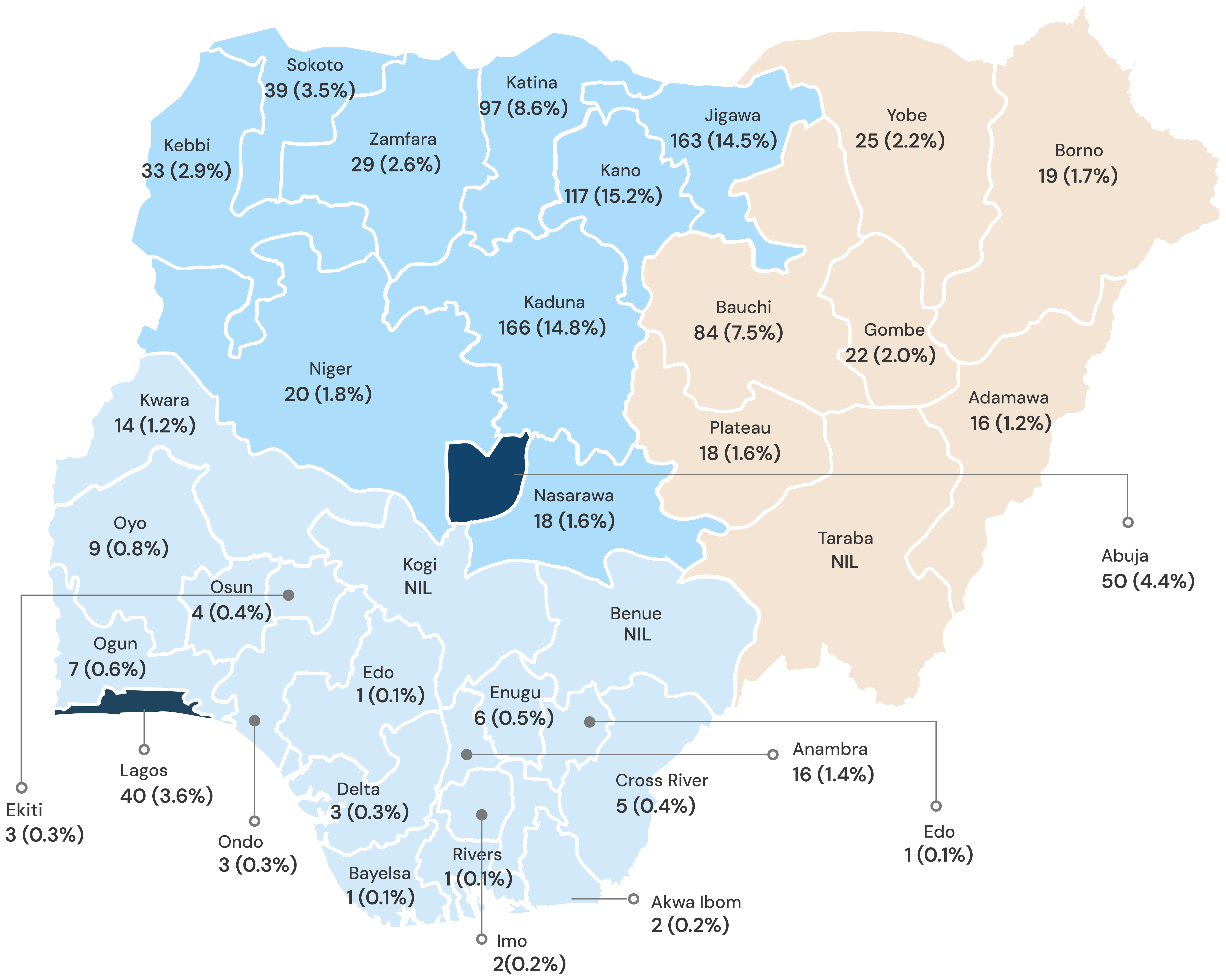
Total respondents: 1214

Methodology

Most respondents came from northern Nigeria. Kano (15.2%), Kaduna (14.8%), and Jigawa (14.5%) were the top three states. Southern states were underrepresented—Lagos, for instance, made up just 3.6% of the sample.

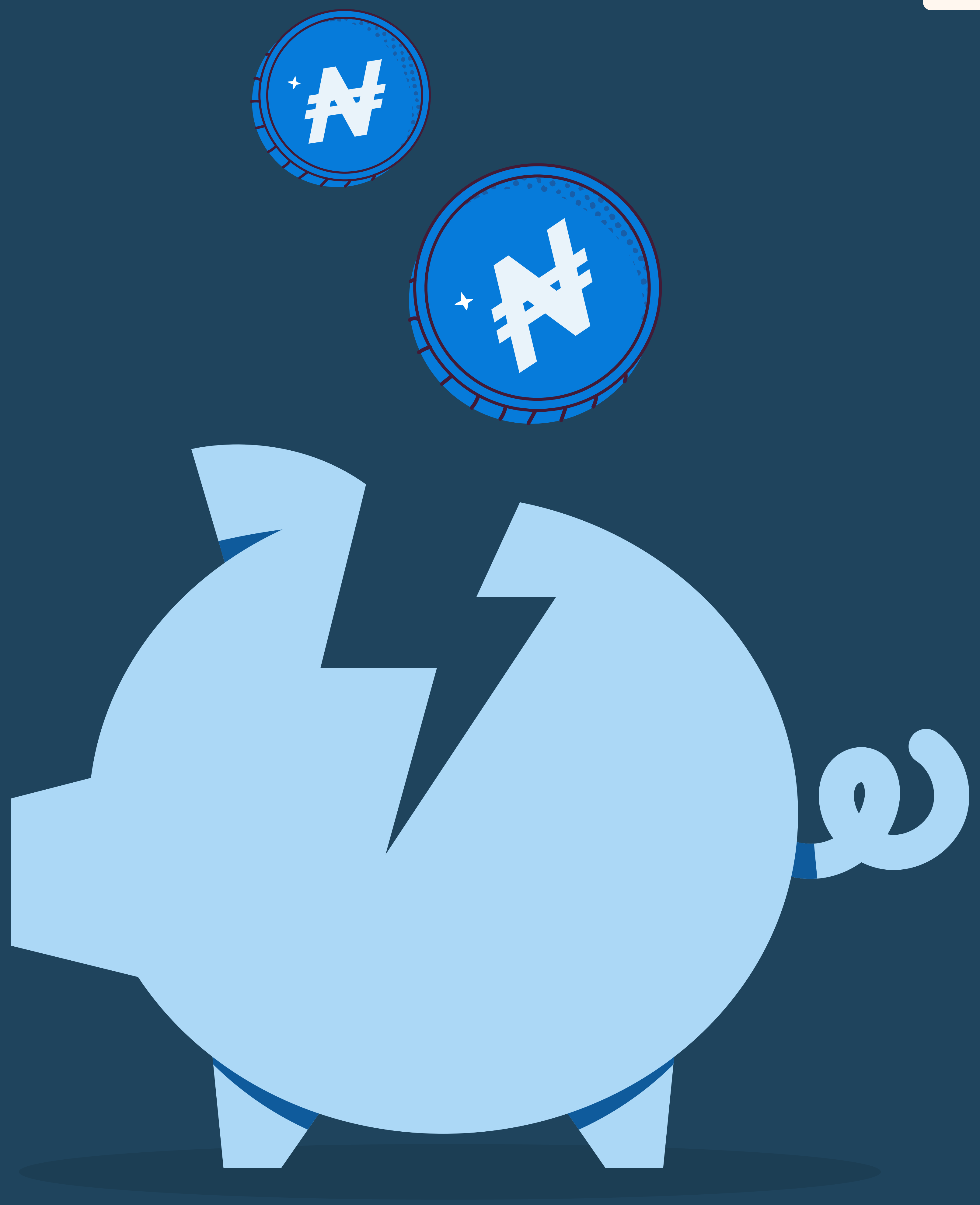
This imbalance likely stems from how Meta's ad delivery algorithm prioritized lower-cost impressions in northern regions, combined with how people in different areas engage with online surveys. It may also reflect differences in mobile connectivity, financial needs, or the appeal of the airtime/cash incentive. As a result, some caution is needed when generalizing the findings across all regions.

Response density by geographical region



Saving and budgeting

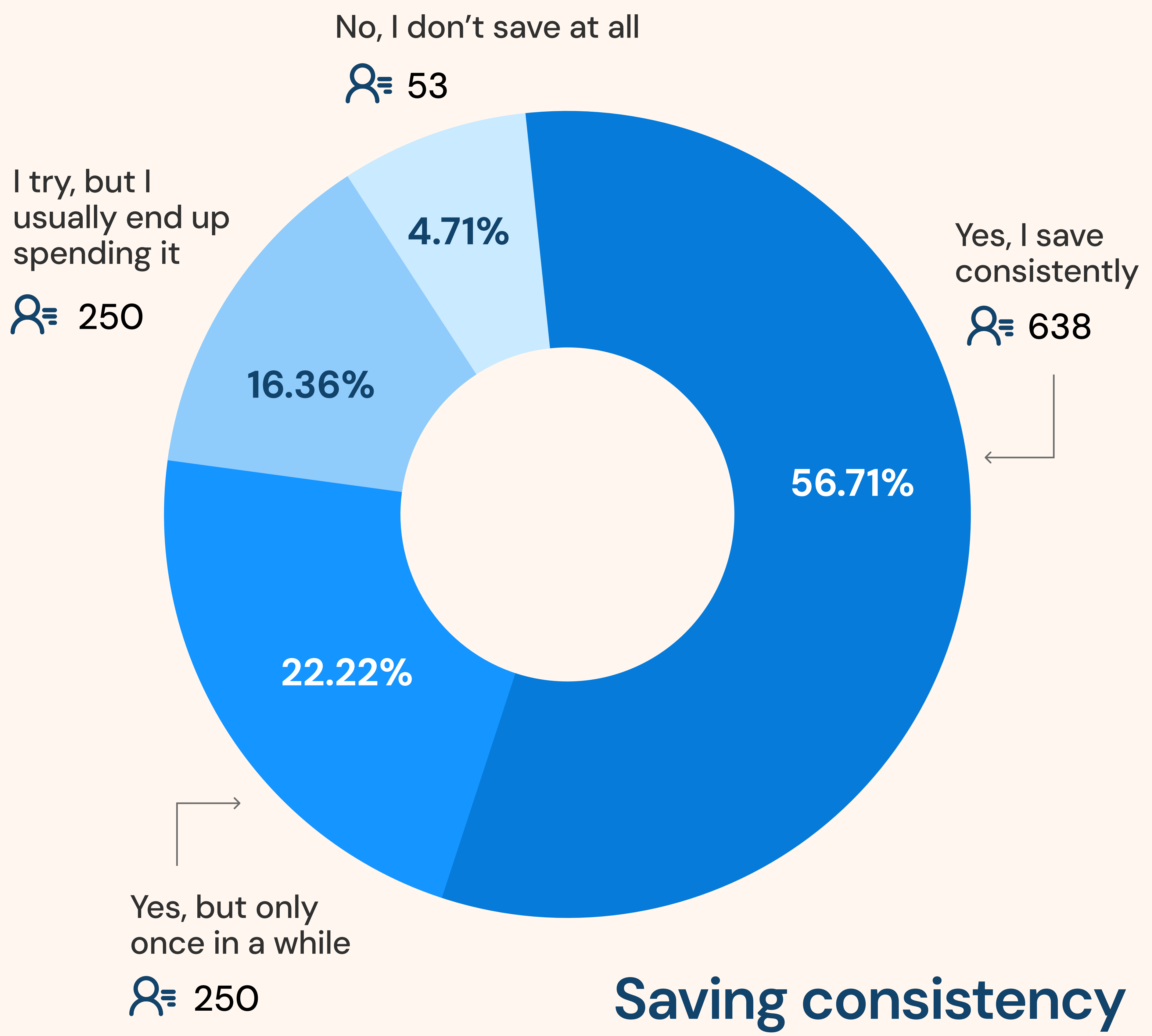
What does saving look like when income is tight? Even with limited income, most respondents try to save and plan their spending. But while intent is high, success rates vary. This section explores how Nigerians approach saving, what motivates them, and where the biggest gaps lie.



General saving behavior

Most respondents say they try to save. 56.7% save consistently, while another 22.2% save once in a while. Only 4.7% don't save at all. This shows that saving is a goal for most, even if they don't always follow through.

For this study, we didn't inquire about income bands, though that may be explored in future reports.



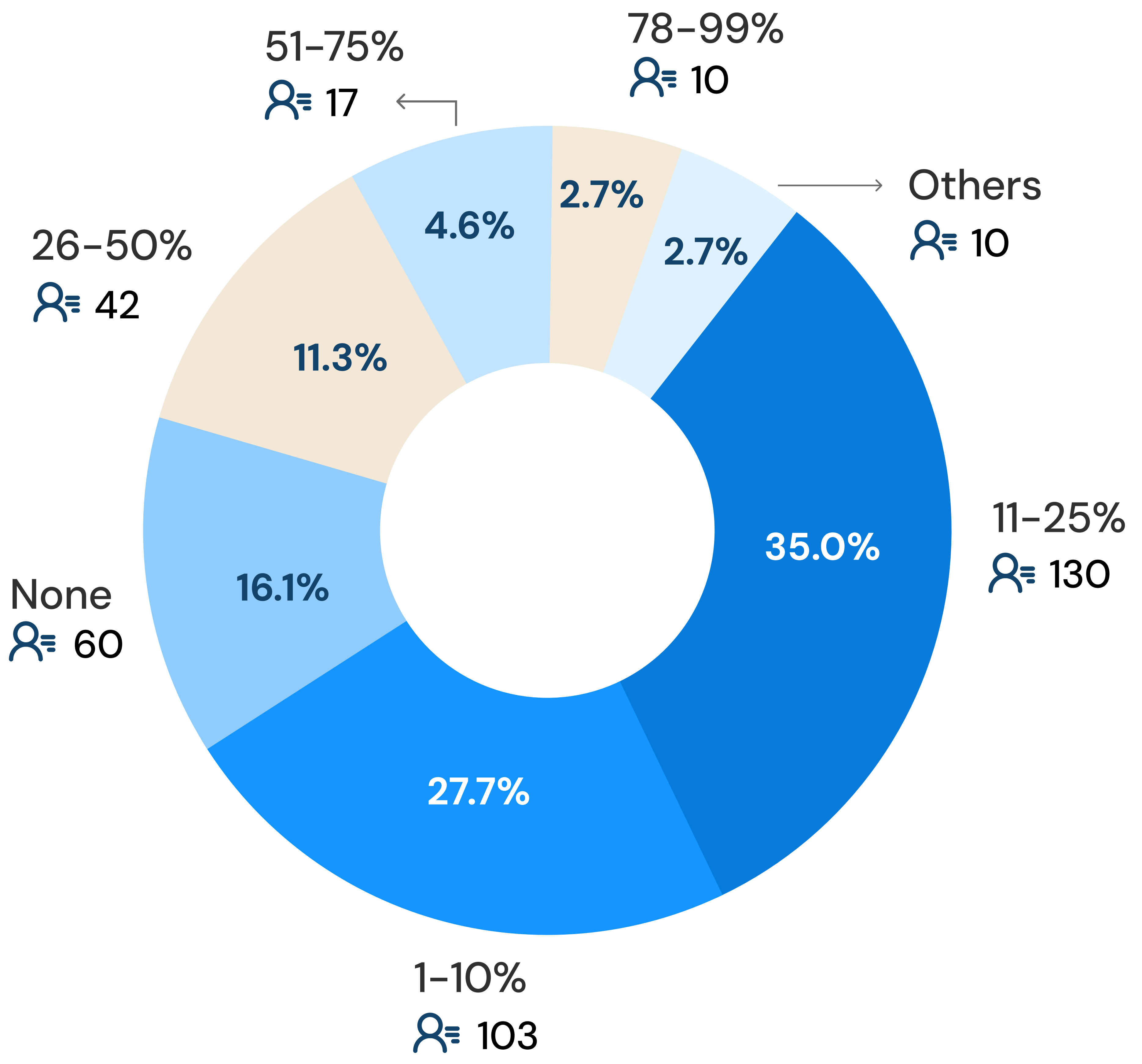
Saving consistency

Monthly saving rate

Looking at how much they save, most respondents put aside small amounts. 35% save between 11–25% of their income, and 27.7% save just 1–10%. About 16.1% save nothing, and a combined 21% save more than half of what they earn. These numbers reflect the financial pressure many Nigerians face—while they may want to save, limited income makes it hard to set aside larger amounts.

On the other hand, some people might be able to save more than half of their income because they're supported by other means (e.g., students on scholarships or living with sponsors) or live in low cost of living areas and earn above-average incomes.

Percentage Saved (%)



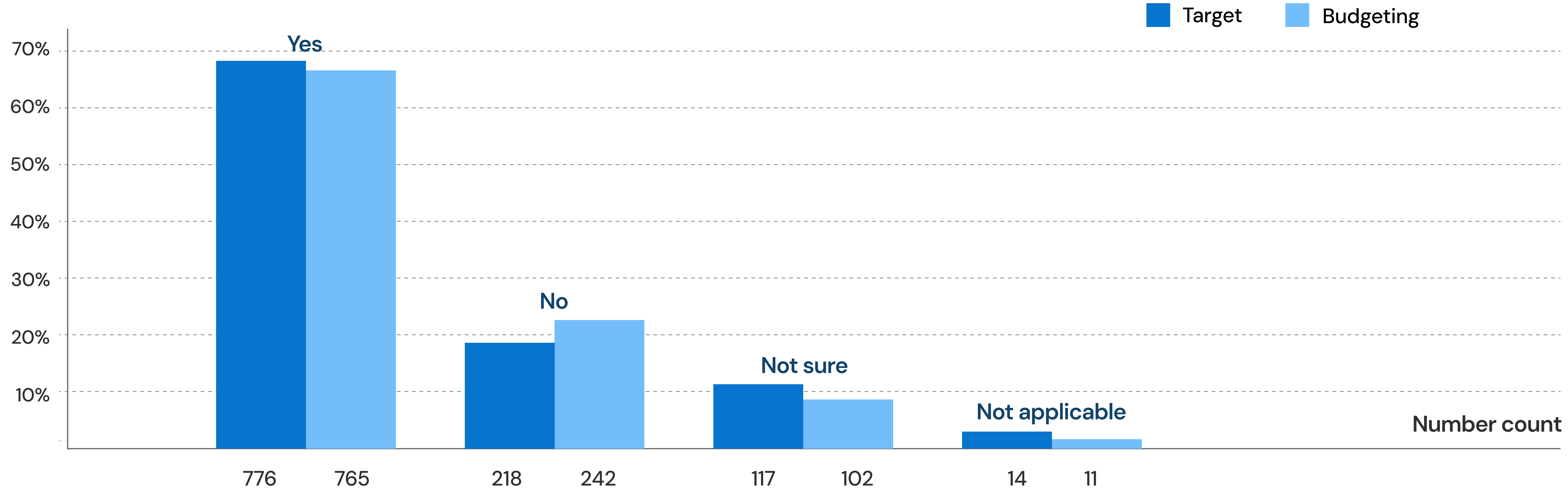
Saving discipline

Most Nigerians are trying to be more intentional with their money. 69% of respondents set a savings target every month, and 68% keep a personal budget or expense plan. Only 9.1% aren't sure if they budget, which suggests growing awareness of the need for financial planning.

Saving goal success

When it comes to actually hitting savings goals, the picture is mixed. 35.3% reached a goal in the last month, and 29.3% did so within 3 months. But 9.8% say they've never hit a savings goal. This shows that while many Nigerians are trying, saving consistently is still a challenge for a significant group.

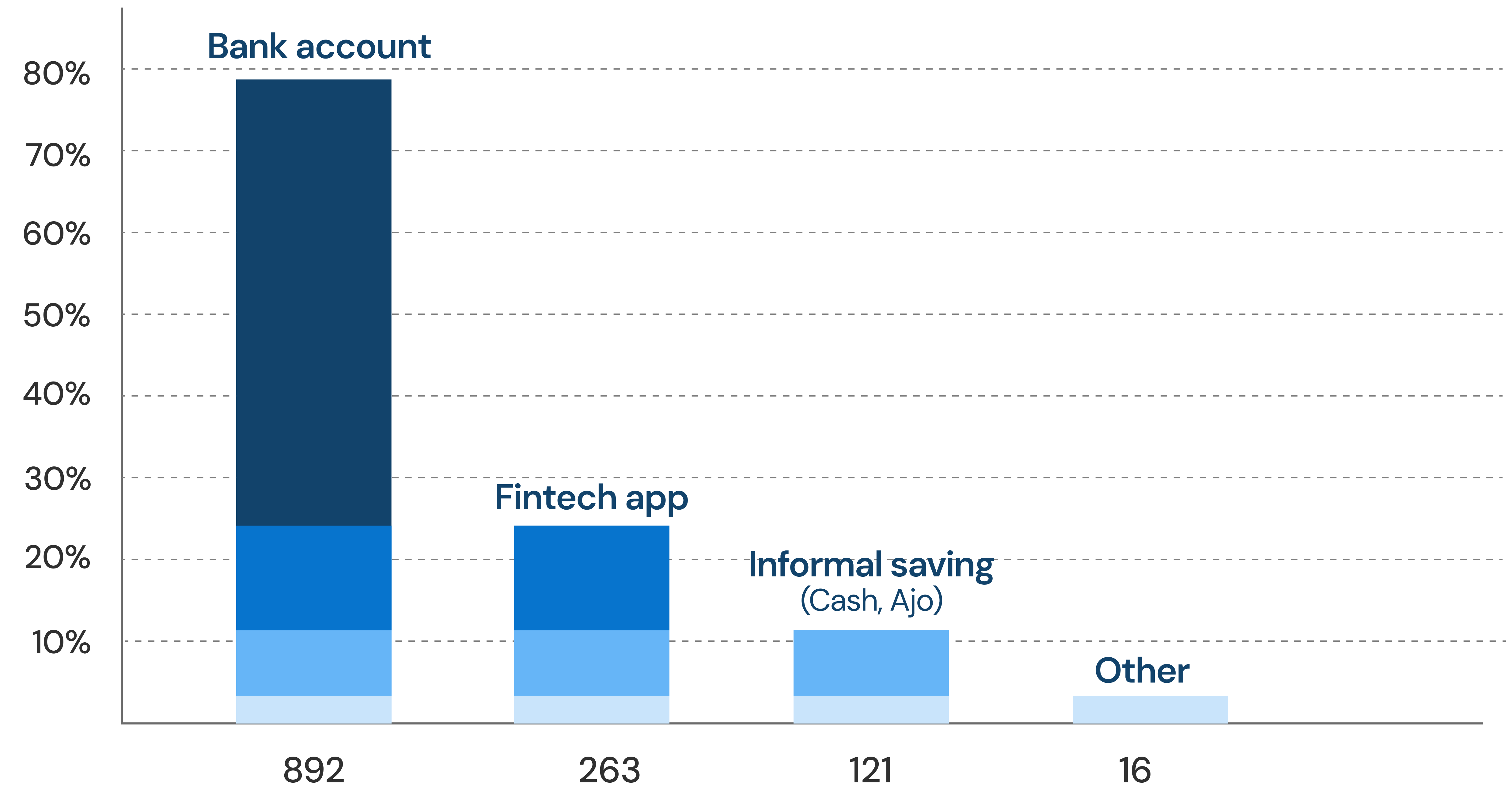
Saving Target + Expense Budget (%)



Savings methods

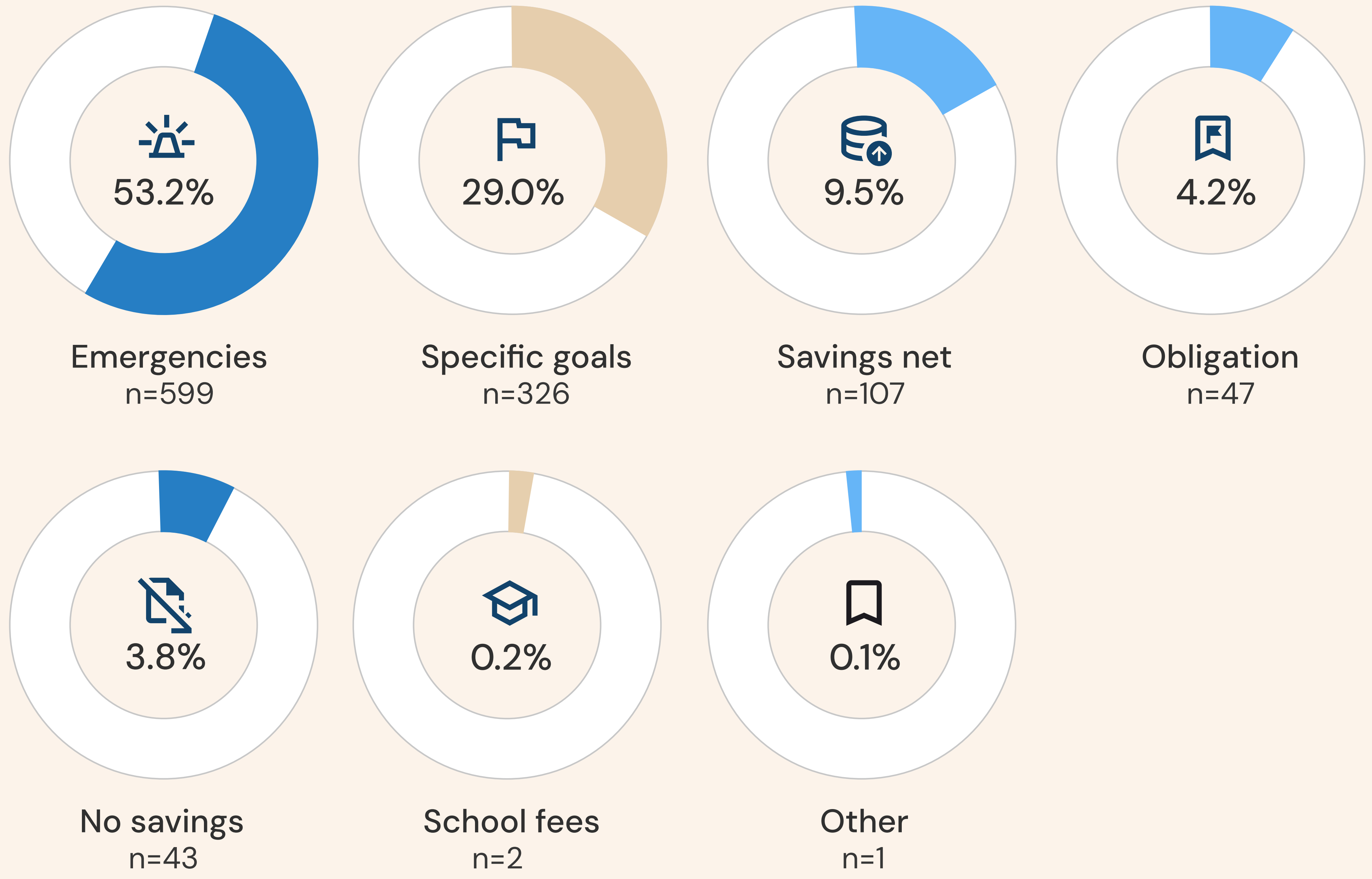
Most people still trust traditional banks when it comes to saving—79.3% keep their money in a bank account. However, fintech apps are gaining ground, with 23.4% using them. About 10.8% rely on informal methods like keeping cash at home or using local saving groups. This mix shows that while digital finance is growing, many Nigerians still prefer familiar or accessible options.

Saving methods



Just under a tenth (9.51%) said they save to build a general safety net, while a smaller number (4.2%) said they save just because they feel they should, even without a clear reason. This shows that for most people, saving is tied to either urgent needs or clear, practical goals.

Reasons for saving money



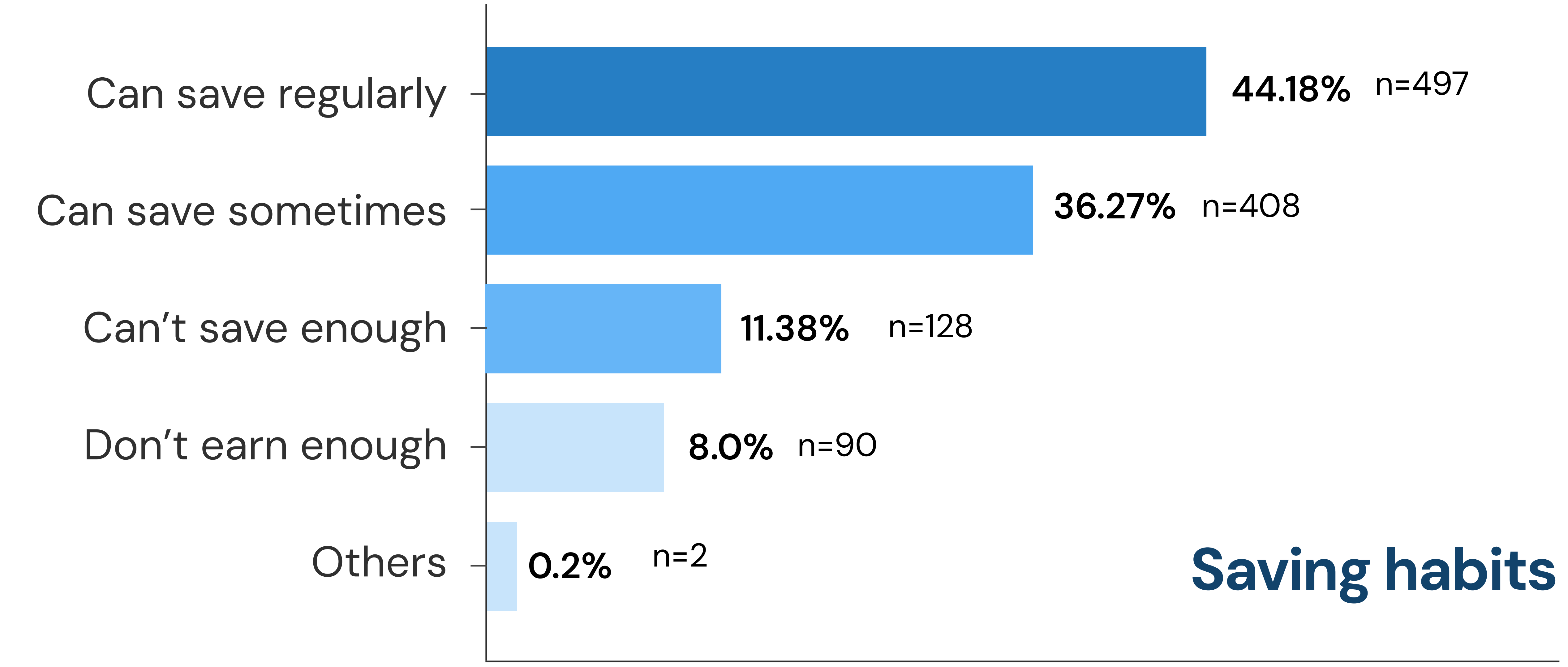
Top savings motivations

When asked why they save, more than half (53.2%) said it's to prepare for emergencies or unexpected costs. Another 28.9% are saving towards specific goals like travel, school, or starting a business.

Income and savings potential

When it comes to income, not everyone has money left over to save. Less than half (44.2%) of Nigerians say they usually have money left over to save, while just over a third (36.3%) of Nigerians can only save sometimes, depending on the month.

About one in five Nigerians (19%) combined say they can't save at all either because their income barely covers basic needs, or they're not currently earning enough to save. This highlights the financial strain many people face: saving isn't just about discipline, but also about ability.



Spending habits

What do Nigerians actually spend their money on—and why? Spending patterns reveal the tension between daily needs and financial goals. From food to family support to unplanned splurges, this section explores how Nigerians spend, track, and react to their financial choices.

Spending awareness

Most respondents say they know how much they spend—66% track their spending in some way. But a sizable number don't: 24% say they don't track, and 10% aren't sure. This shows that while many are paying attention to where their money goes, there's still a big group who could benefit from simple tracking tools.

Top expense categories

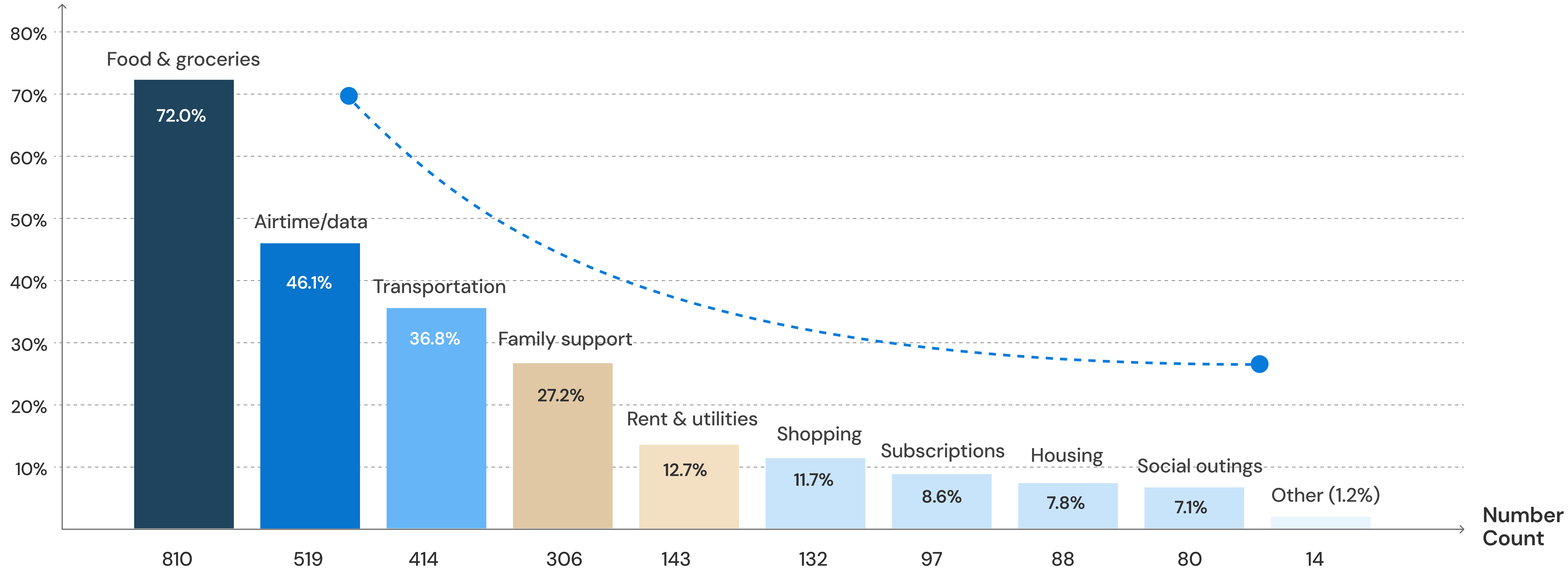
This question asked respondents to select all the areas where they spend money in a typical month. The results don't show how much people spend, but they do show how common each category is.

Food and groceries appeared on the most lists—72.0% of respondents selected it—followed by airtime/data (46.1%), transportation (36.8%), and family support (27.2%). These categories point to the basics of survival and connectivity, and the financial role many young Nigerians play in supporting others. Shopping (like clothes or electronics) was listed as a common monthly expense by 11.7%. Only 8.6% included subscriptions like Netflix or Spotify—suggesting that for most people, non-essentials take a back seat.

Rent and utilities were selected by 12.7% of respondents, perhaps reflecting the respondent pool. Many in the sample may live with family or in shared accommodation, reducing or eliminating rent obligations. While Nigeria faces a well-documented housing shortage, rental costs are high in many cities, and homeownership remains out of reach for most young people. As a result, respondents might not bear monthly rent directly—either because they aren't yet independent or because rent is paid annually, making it less top-of-mind as a recurring monthly expense.

This isn't a breakdown of budgets, but it confirms that essential needs dominate. Any financial product, retail strategy, or support program must begin with the real costs Nigerians face month to month.

Expense categories



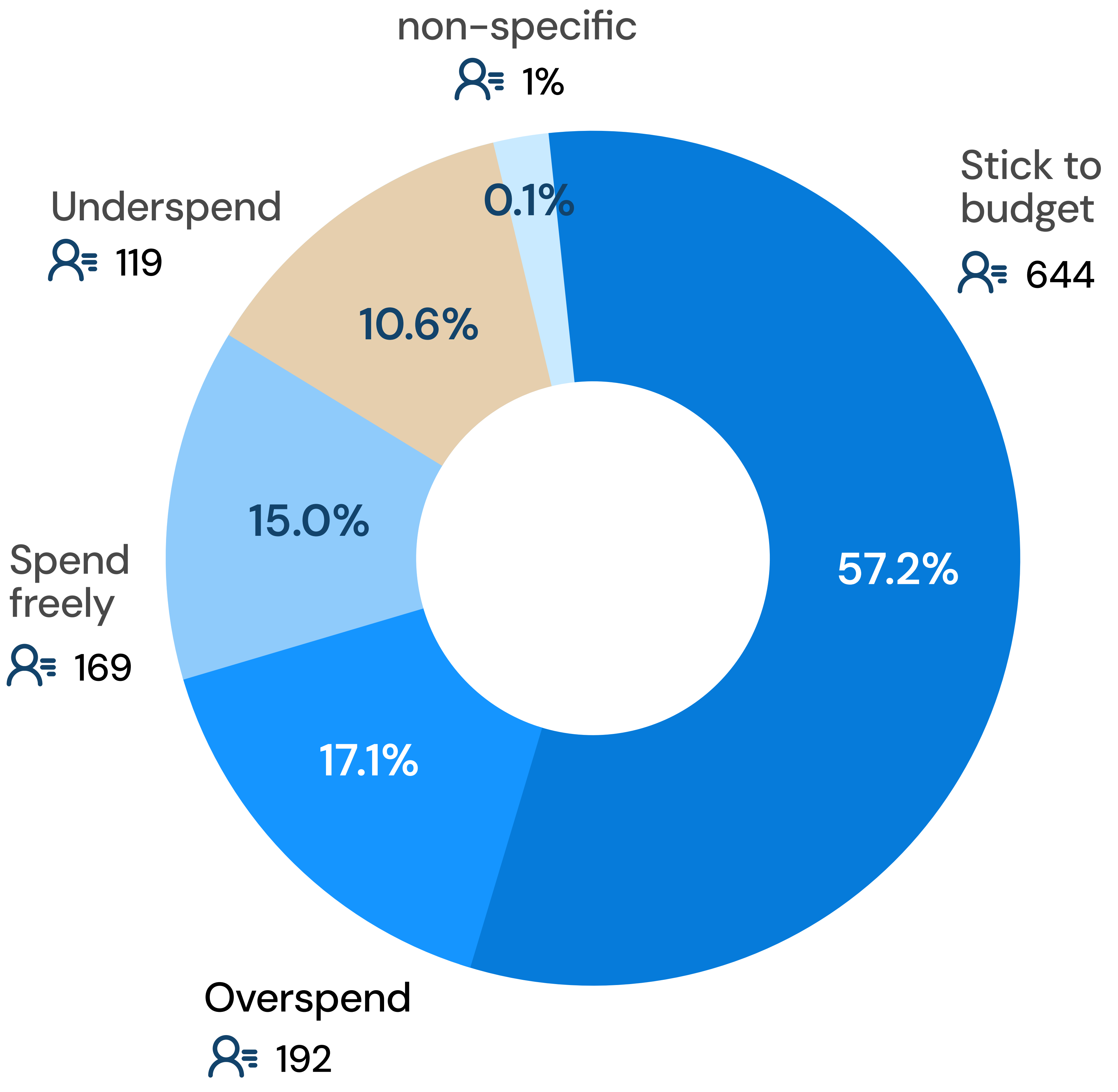
Spending discipline

Nigerians are split when it comes to managing how they spend. Just over half (57.2%) say they stick to a budget, showing some level of control. Others admit to challenges: 17.1% say they often overspend, and 15% don't use a budget at all. Interestingly, 10.6% say they actually spend less than expected.

For a mostly young population—many of whom are students or self-employed—this could mean a few things. Some may be practicing caution, spending conservatively to stretch limited funds. Others might simply lack the means to spend more, making "underspending" less a choice and more a reflection of low income. It's also possible that lifestyle simplicity—living at home, subsidized costs, or postponed purchases—keeps monthly spending low. Either way, the gap between intention and action offers insight into how this group navigates financial pressure.

This mix highlights that budgeting isn't one-size-fits-all. Some treat it as a tool, others as a constraint, and for some, it's simply not part of the picture.

Spending habits



Overspending reasons

Why may some overspend? For many Nigerians, it's not due to recklessness. 45.6% say they simply underestimated how much things would cost, and 28.8% pointed to emergencies. Only 16.8% admitted to not sticking to their budget.

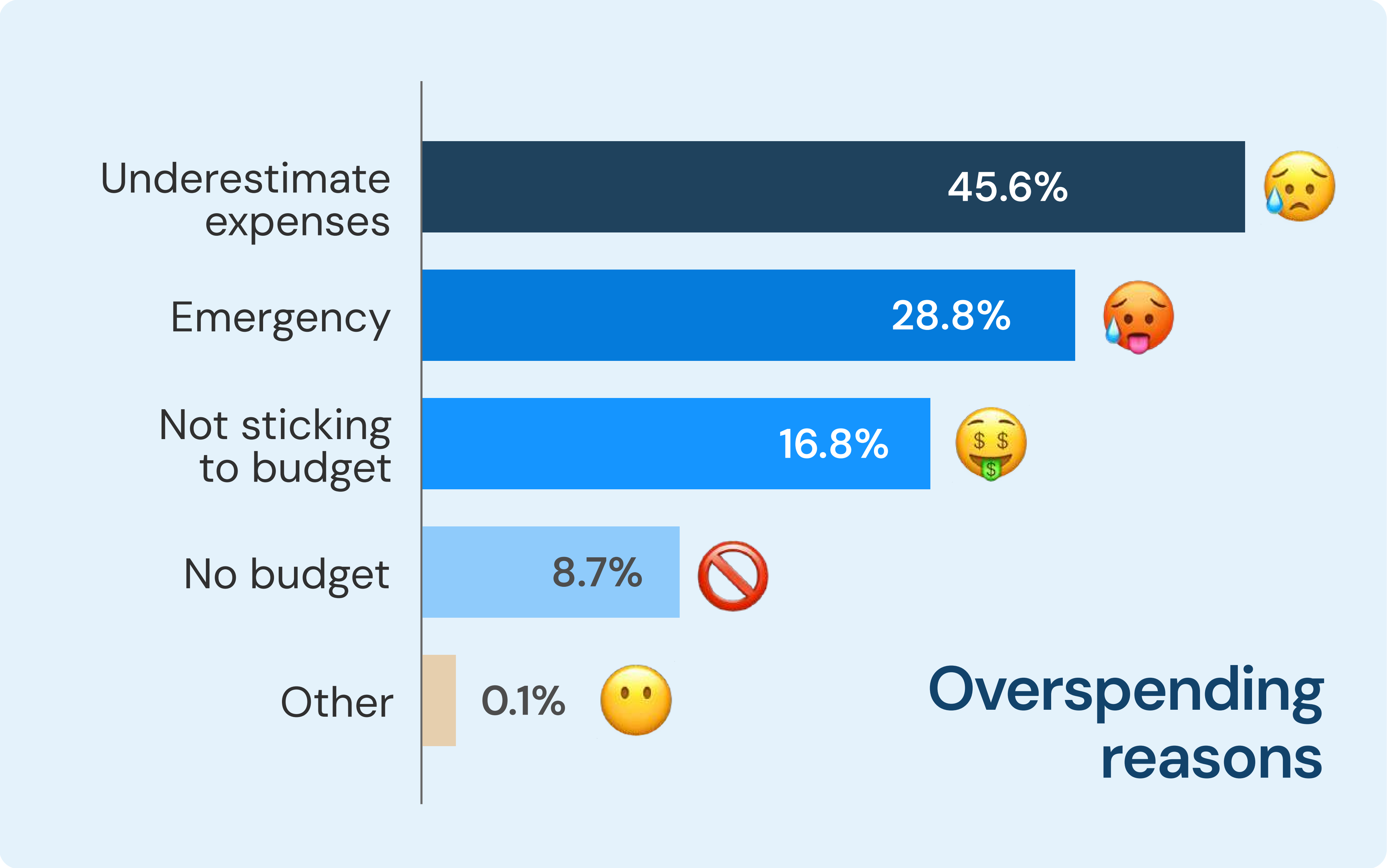
This points to overspending as mostly unintentional—often the result of real-life pressures or miscalculations. In an economy where prices shift rapidly, even a well-planned budget can fall apart. Inflation, in particular, makes it harder to predict costs—so people who thought they were budgeting smartly may still end up spending more than expected.

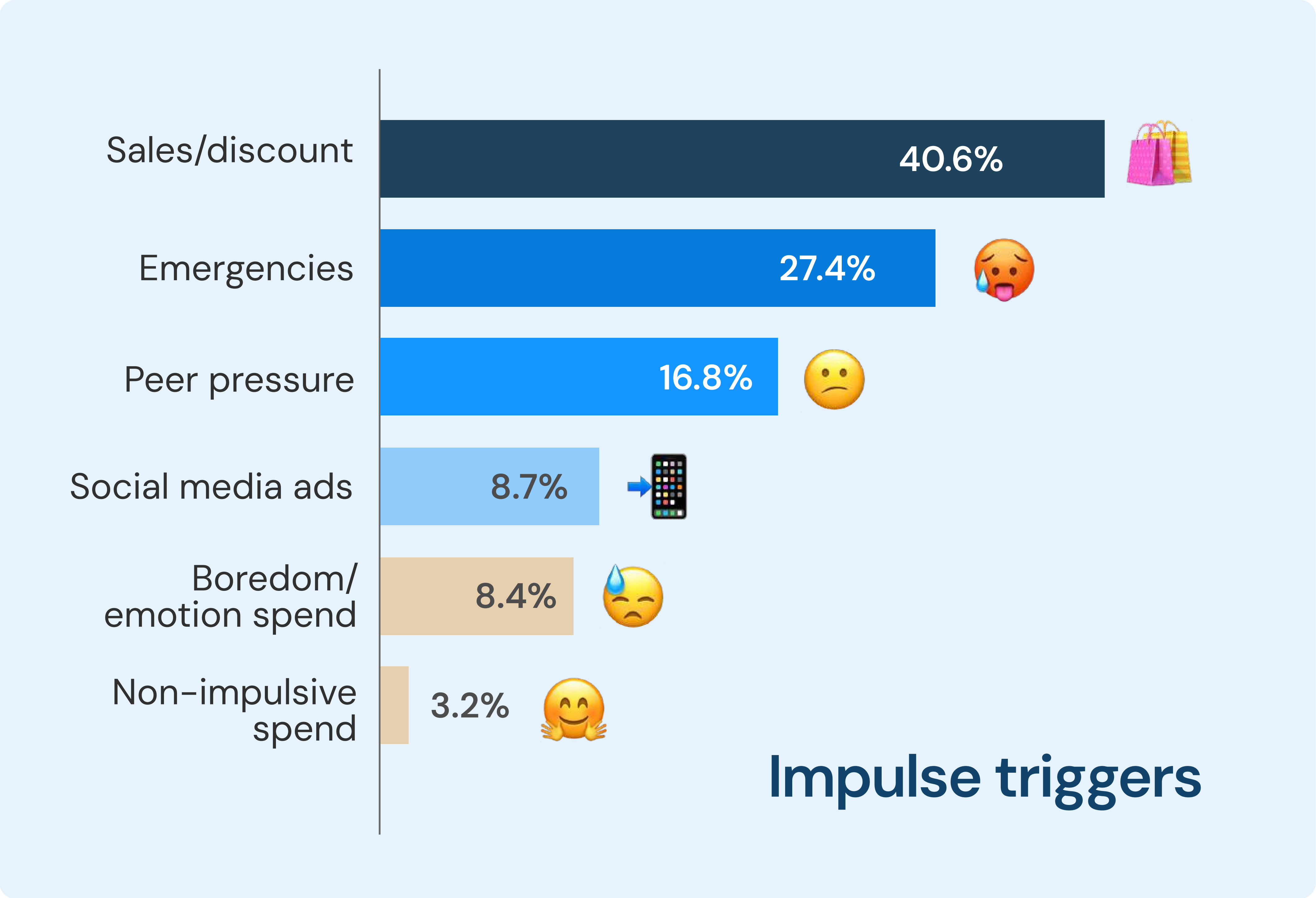
Triggers for impulse spending

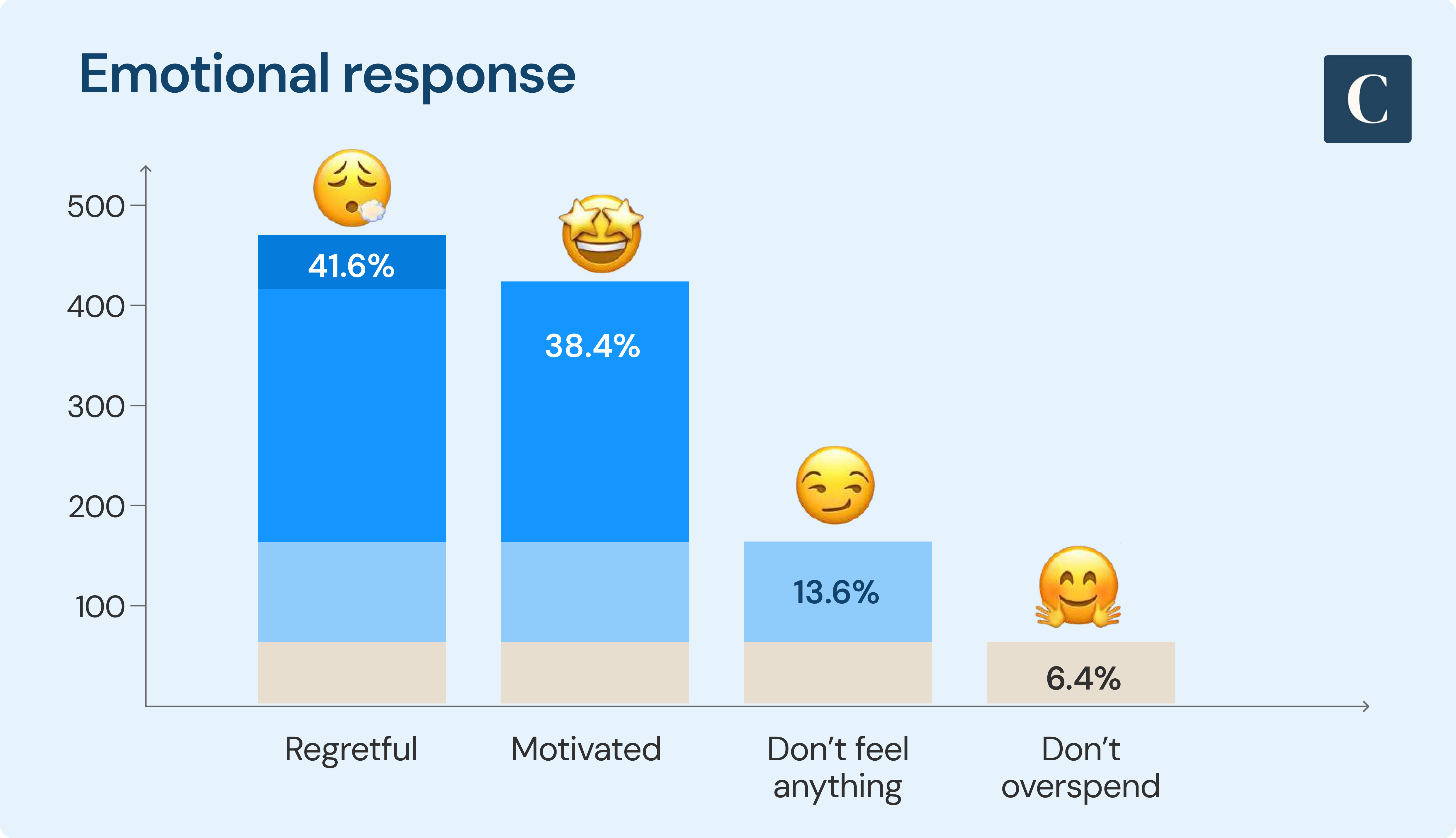
When spending goes off-script, it's usually due to outside pressure. Sales and discounts were the biggest trigger (40.6%), followed by emergencies (27.4%). A mix of peer pressure, social media, and emotional spending made up the rest. This shows how both marketing tactics and social cues can easily disrupt good intentions.

Emotional response to overspending

How do people feel afterward? 41.6% of Nigerians report regret after overspending, while 38.4% feel motivated to get back on track. A smaller group—13.6%—feel nothing at all, and 6.4% said they rarely overspend. These responses suggest that overspending carries an emotional cost, but also opens a door for reflection and change.







Expense tracking methods

Expense tracking isn't common among Nigerians yet. Per our data, 36.9% of Nigerians don't track their spending at all, which means many likely have limited visibility into where their money goes. Among those who do track, 35.4% do so manually—using notebooks or notes apps. Only 12.7% rely on bank statements, while 9.6% use spreadsheets and 5.2% use budgeting apps.

At first glance, this might look like a simple gap in awareness or tools. But in an economy where prices shift unpredictably, tracking expenses might feel pointless. If NGN 100 buys you less tomorrow than it did yesterday, there might be little value in recording it. You're no longer budgeting—you're merely adapting to a moving target.

With volatile inflation, people often abandon strict financial planning and adopt a reactive "wait and see" mindset.

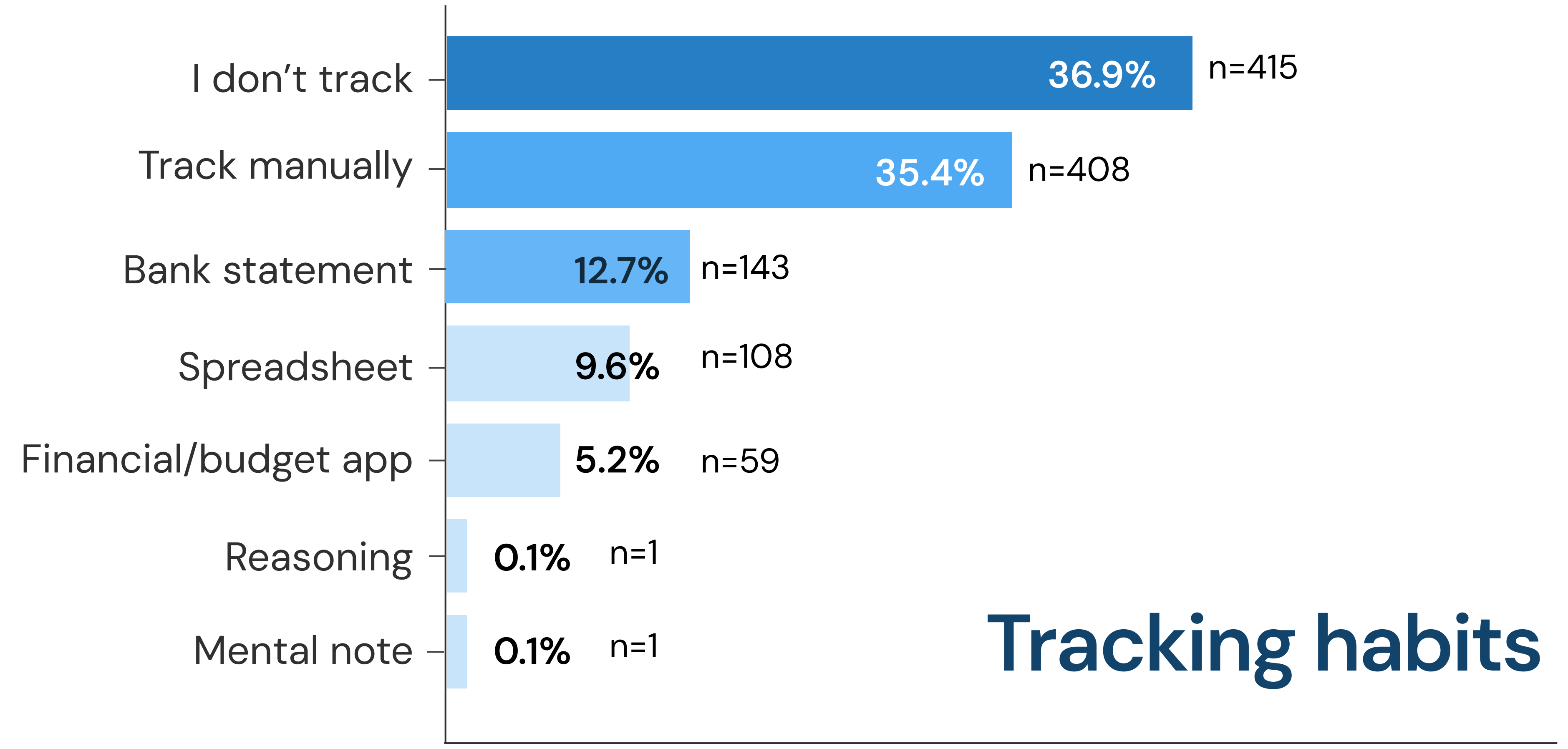
There's also the issue of unstable income. Many respondents are students, entrepreneurs, or freelancers—groups whose income fluctuates. In such situations, expense tracking may feel aspirational rather than useful. If you don't know what you'll earn next week, it's hard to plan for what you'll spend.

Then there's the question of digital trust and usability. Manual tracking remains dominant because it's familiar, private, and easy to control. Budgeting apps, while promising in theory, may feel too complicated, data-hungry, or unfamiliar.

Most banking apps in Nigeria today have improved dashboards, but they're still primarily built for general money management—not for detailed expense tracking. Features like categorization, visualization, receipt scanning, budgeting, and forecasting are often missing or underdeveloped, making them less suited for users who want a full picture of their spending habits.

Finally, for many, this is about bandwidth. When financial survival is your daily priority, tracking becomes a luxury. People aren't being careless—they're likely overwhelmed. Between rising prices, social pressure, and income gaps, logging every transaction may be the last thing on their minds.

All of this points to a deeper opportunity: the need for tracking tools that are simple, automated, mobile-first, and built for people who are juggling uncertainty—not just those chasing optimization.



Tracking habits

Use of financial tools & technology

What happens when digital tools are everywhere—but deep financial engagement is still rare? This section looks at how Nigerians use financial apps, what features they value most, and where the biggest opportunities lie for tech-driven solutions.

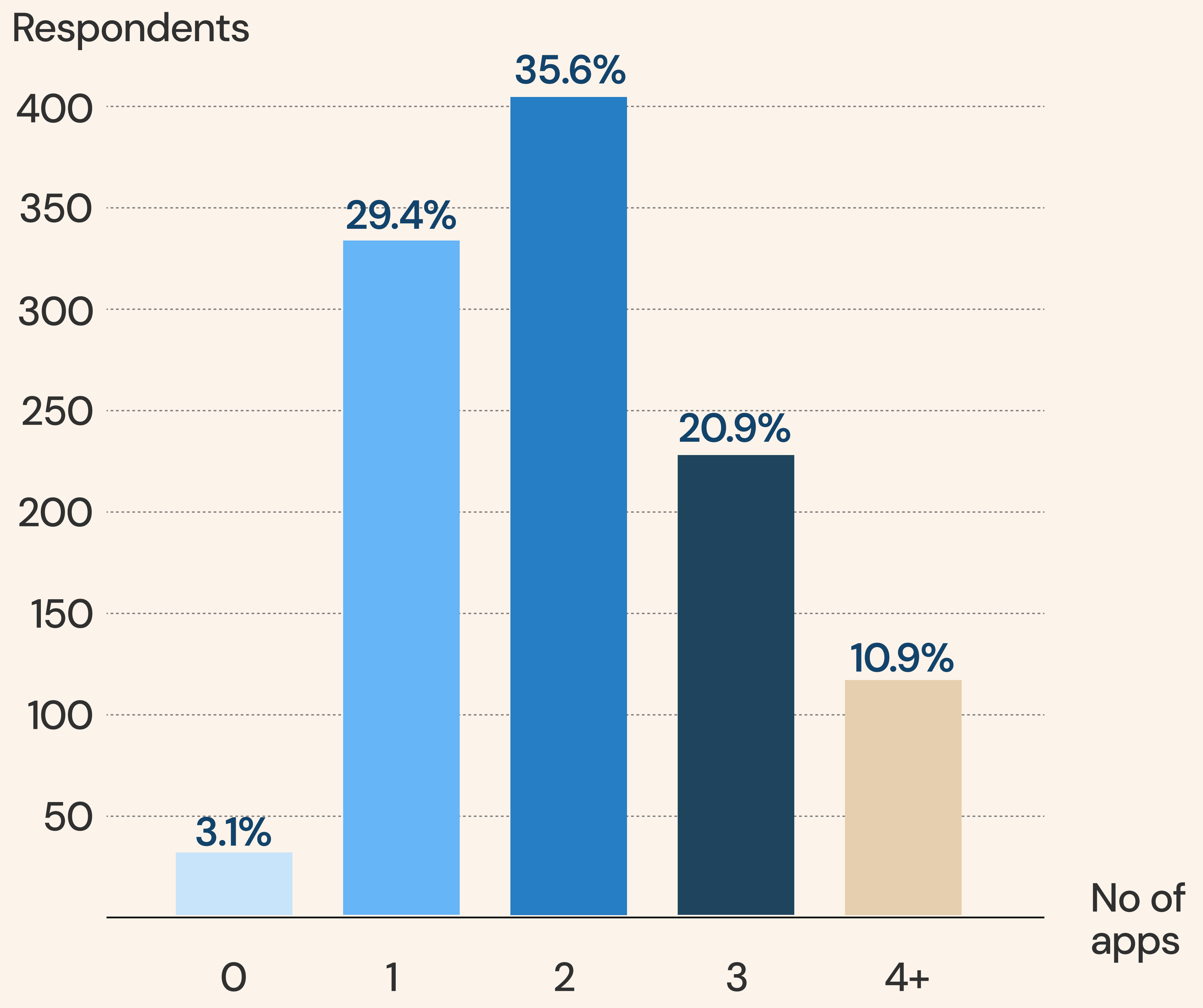
App usage frequency

Most Nigerians surveyed use more than one financial app. 35.6% use two apps, 29.4% use just one, and 20.9% use three. Only 3.1% don't use any apps at all. This shows that digital financial tools are now a regular part of daily life for many Nigerians, even if usage is still shallow for some.

Top financial apps used

The most popular apps are clearly mobile-first platforms. Opay leads by a large margin at 63.9%, followed by Palmpay (15.3%), Kuda (9.75%), and Moniepoint (6.53%). Traditional banking apps and savings platforms like PiggyVest, UBA Mobile App, or Cowrywise make up a much smaller share — each under 3%. This highlights a shift toward fast, flexible, and mobile-based services that serve day-to-day needs. Note that the survey attracted more responses from northern states, so regional market share differences may skew the data.

Number of financial apps used



Top fintech apps used by Nigerians, 2025

App	Count	Percentage
1. OPay	714	63.86%
2. PalmPay	171	15.30%
3. kuda.	109	9.75%
4. Moniepoint	73	6.53%
5. piggyvest	32	2.86%
6. UBA	11	0.98%
7. cowrywise	15	1.34%
8. FCMB	6	0.54%
9. FairMoney	5	0.45%
10. SmartCash	5	0.45%
11. FirstBank Since 1894	7	0.63%
12. GTCO GTBank	8	0.72%
13. Zenith Bank	7	0.63%
14. access	8	0.72%
15. POLARIS BANK Polaris	3	0.27%
16. WEMA BANK	3	0.27%
17. Bamboo	3	0.27%

Demand for integrated tools

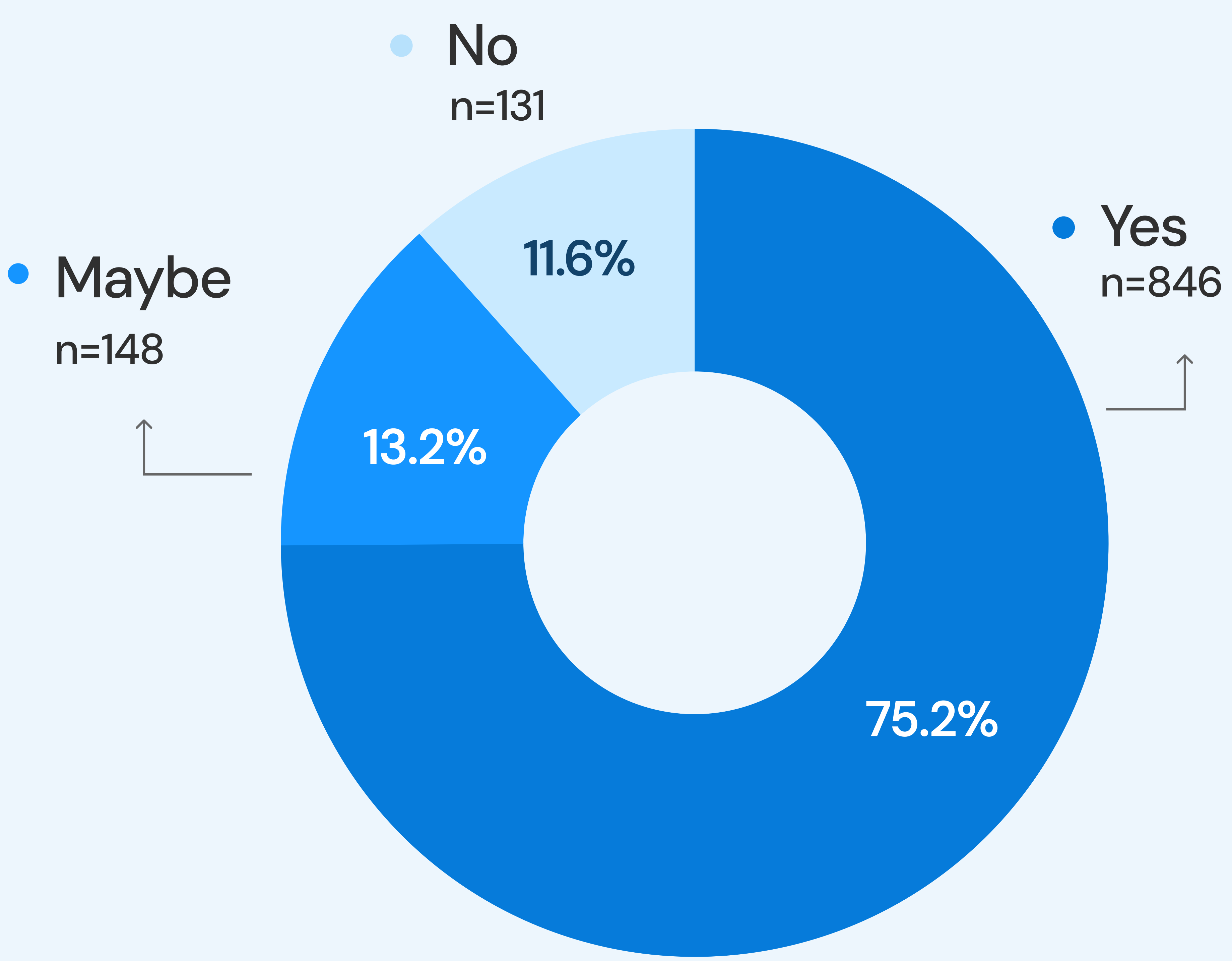
There's a clear desire for simplicity and control. 75.2% of respondents said they want to see all their financial activity in one place, like a single app or dashboard. Only 11.6% said they don't, and the rest are unsure. With three in four Nigerians in favour of centralized financial activity, this suggests that most people are overwhelmed juggling between different accounts, apps, and services. It points to a major product opportunity: tools or features that help users manage money without switching between platforms.

Most valued app features

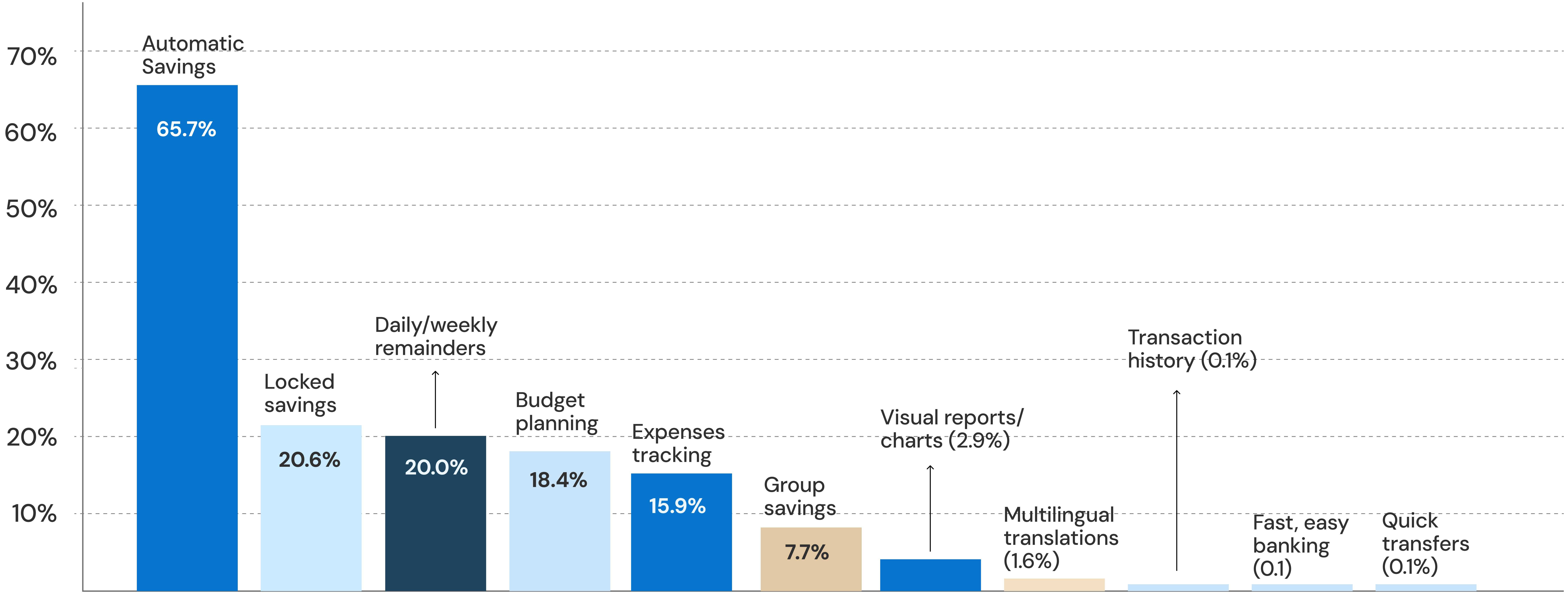
When asked what features matter most, automatic savings was the top pick (65.7%). This reflects a strong desire to build discipline without too much effort. Locked savings (20.6%), budget planning (18.4%), and expense tracking (15.9%) also stood out. There was some interest in reminders (20%) and group saving (7.7%), but convenience and automation clearly lead. The more a tool can help users save or manage without requiring daily effort, the more attractive it becomes.

Demand for consolidated activity

Q: "Would you like to see all your financial activity in one place?"



Top desired features



Mobile network usage

If most people are on one network, how can this position be leveraged?

Network usage

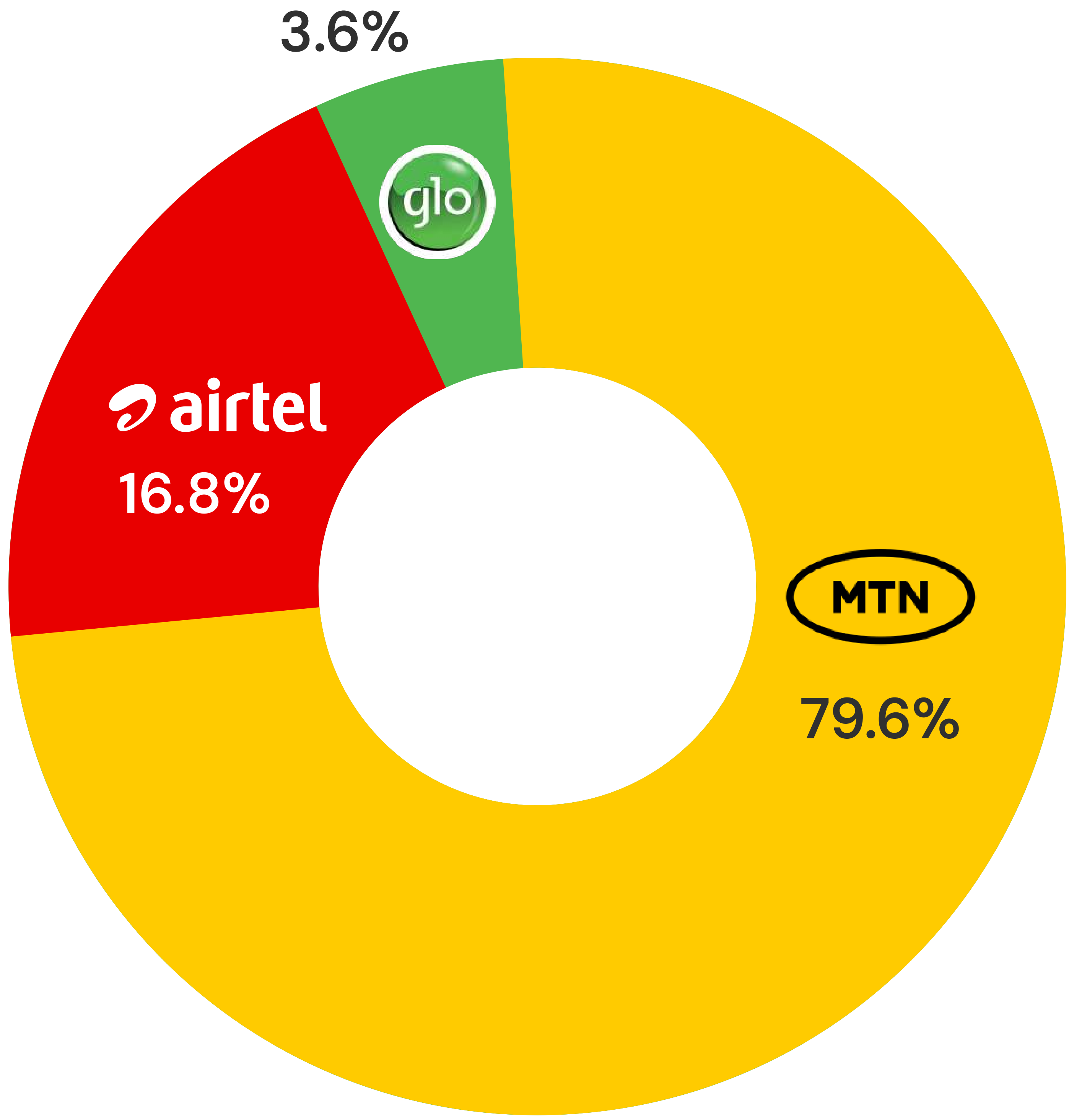
MTN dominates with 79.6% of respondents using their network, followed by Airtel at 16.8% (other sources suggest MTN broadly commands 52.4% of the Nigerian market while Airtel commands 33.9%). All other networks combined make up just 3.6%. This massive lead for MTN suggests that any financial product or reward linked to mobile data or airtime is best delivered through MTN first.

This also ties directly to spending habits: airtime and data were the second-most common expense after food, with 46.1% of respondents listing it as a major monthly cost. That's a huge opportunity for telecom companies to ease financial stress by providing flexible plans, reward-based saving bundles, or even micro-loans or discounts linked to usage patterns.

The opportunity goes beyond airtime. Broadband packages are an increasingly essential part of daily life, especially for young, mobile-savvy Nigerians. When people are already spending so much on food, transport, and mobile data, bundled broadband rewards or discounts could ease pressure—and win loyalty.

For telcos, there's a clear path to deepen market share: make connectivity feel like a value-added financial service, not just a utility.

Network usage percentage



Discussion and implications for the public and private sector

What role should each sector play when so many Nigerians are trying—but struggling—to stay financially afloat? This section breaks down what the data means for key industries—from banks and fintechs to policymakers and retail brands. It offers clear, actionable ideas for how each one can respond to the financial realities uncovered in this report.

Banks: From storage lockers to financial partners

Traditional banks remain the most common way to save—79.3% of Nigerians keep their money in bank accounts. But this likely reflects habit, accessibility, or institutional trust more than deliberate preference. Banks are familiar, not necessarily flexible.

That puts banks at risk of becoming passive storage lockers—places where money sits without being actively managed. Yet today's users want more. Respondents showed clear interest in automatic savings (65.7%), budgeting tools (18.4%), and—most notably—the ability to see all their financial activity in one place (75.2%). These are features fintech apps already prioritize.

For Nigerian banks to stay relevant in this shift, they can:

- Build savings tools that are simple, automated, and goal-linked.
- Create digital experiences that match the usability of fintech platforms.
- Leverage their large customer base to offer integrated personal finance dashboards—helping users visualize spending, track habits, and plan ahead.
- Explore adding AI into their offerings backed by strong digital governance

But to truly meet the demand for unified financial visibility, banks also need to lean into open banking. That means enabling secure access to customer data across platforms, so users can view their bank, wallet, and savings activity in one place. This is already common in countries like the UK, where open banking frameworks support a single dashboard view across financial providers.

Nigeria has made early moves in this direction, but adoption remains slow. For banks, this is a missed opportunity. Embracing open banking—through partnerships or secure APIs—can turn banks into financial command centers, not just storage vaults.

This is also a key moment to close the expense tracking gap. Over a third of users (36.9%) don't track their spending, and most rely on low-tech methods like notes apps or mental math. With smart nudges, automated categorization, and built-in insights, banks can move from being passive vaults to active allies in daily money management.

Fintechs: Becoming the user's financial home base

Fintech apps are well-placed to lead the next chapter of personal finance in Nigeria. But there's still a big gap between what users want and what they currently use. Only 23.4% of users say they use fintech apps for saving, yet far more show interest in features like automatic saving, budgeting, and expense tracking.

To close this gap, fintechs should:

Automate savings and spending management so users don't have to overthink or micromanage money. Existing apps like Opay and PiggyVest already offer this.

Simplify budgeting tools with visual, easy-to-use designs that help users stay on track.

Offer account integrations that pull information from multiple banks and wallets into one dashboard.

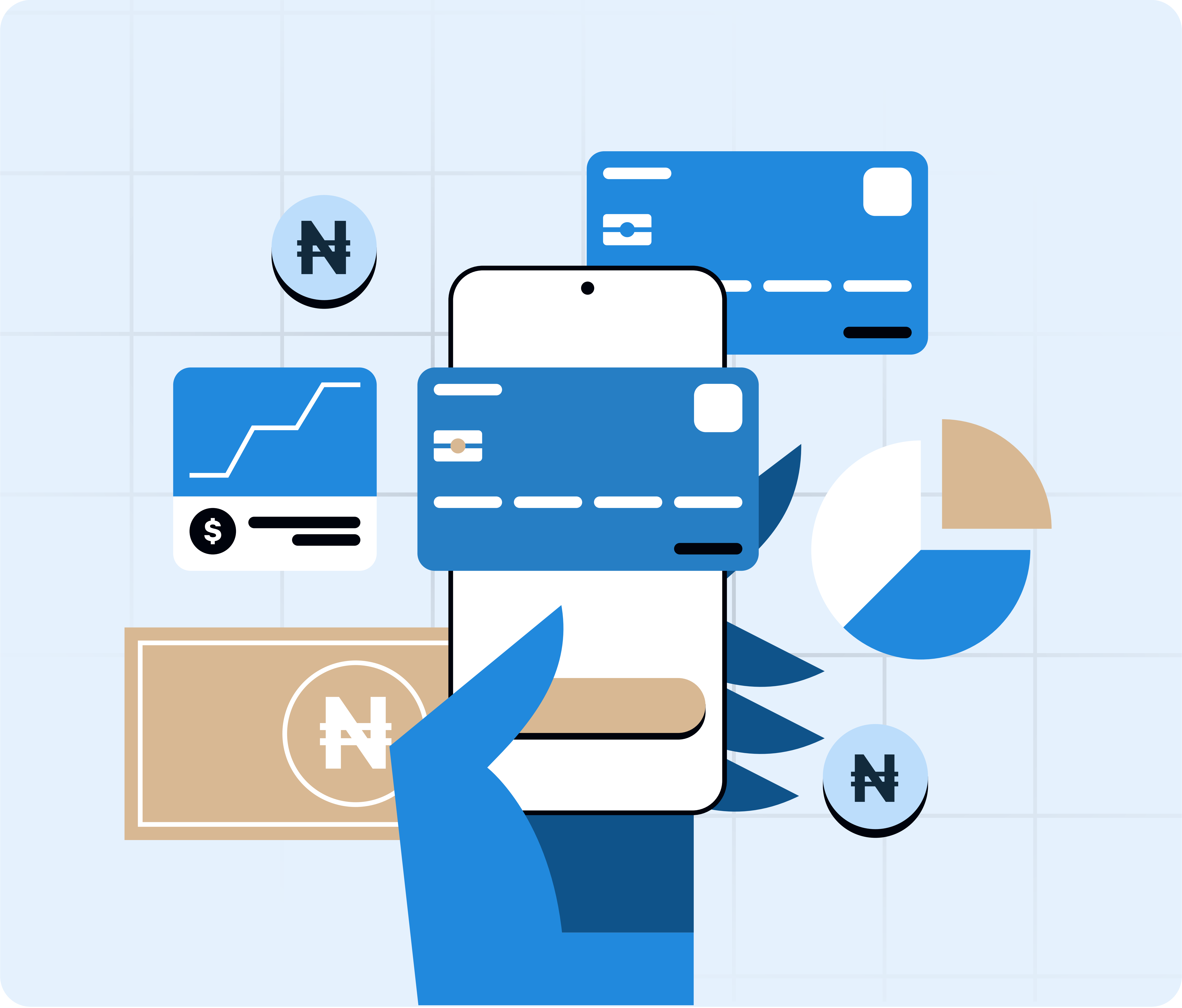
Partner with retailers to help users set savings goals for specific products or link spending to preset budgets—making it easier to plan purchases and avoid impulse spending.

This matters because users aren't tied to a single provider. Most people use multiple financial apps, mixing banks, wallets, and budgeting tools. That puts fintechs in a strong position to become the main hub for money management, even if they're not where the money is stored.

In a mobile-first market like Nigeria—where apps like **Opay and Palmpay** dominate daily use—fintechs that offer speed, reliability, and low data usage will continue to lead, especially with younger users who live fully on mobile.

There's also a big gap in expense tracking. 36.9% of Nigerians don't track their expenses at all, and most who do use manual methods. This creates a huge opportunity for fintechs to embed simple, automatic tracking into the user experience—quietly adding value without extra effort.

The next wave of innovation will come from useful partnerships—with retailers, telcos, utility providers, or transport platforms—and smoother tools. Fintechs that make money management easier, smarter, and more connected to daily life will win long-term loyalty.



Policymakers: Keeping up with innovation

The data shows clear gaps that government and policy efforts can help close. First, many people don't save—19% of Nigerians say they can't save at all, mostly because their income is too low or too unreliable. Supporting young people with jobs, small business support, and more steady income or payroll runs could help improve financial stability.

Second, rising prices make it harder for people to plan their money. In 2024, Nigeria's inflation stayed above 30% for most of the year and peaked at 34.8% in December. Even though it slowed to around 24% by early 2025, prices are still changing too often. In that kind of environment, many people may feel it's pointless to plan ahead. That might explain why 36.9% of Nigerians surveyed don't track their spending, and only 5.2% use budgeting apps. Government-backed campaigns or programs could rebuild trust in tools like budgets, especially for young earners just starting out.

Third, access to digital tools really matters. Most people now use their phones to manage money, and apps like **Opay** and **Palmpay** are becoming essential. The government can support this shift by creating policies that make it easier for telcos to offer affordable data—like lowering spectrum fees, reducing telecom taxes, or investing in shared infrastructure. That matters especially since airtime/data is the second most common spending area after food.

Supporting the growth of fintech apps won't just help people budget better. It could also give the government stronger real-time data on how households earn, spend, and save. With that kind of insight, policies could be better designed to help where it's needed most.

Lastly, regulation must keep up with innovation. Nigeria already has rules for digital finance—through CBN's licensing frameworks and data protection policies like the Nigeria Data Protection Regulation (NDPR 2019) but many of these focus on system compliance rather than the user experience.

As fintech adoption grows, especially among young people, there's a need to strengthen and update these rules to reflect how people actually use these tools.

In 2023, the Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN) released open banking guidelines that let banks and fintechs safely share customer-approved data through standard systems (APIs). This step is meant to boost competition and improve access to financial tools. But progress is still slow. Today, 75.2% of Nigerians want to see all their financial activity in one place, yet many still use different apps without a full picture of their money.

To close this gap, the government can:

- Help banks and fintechs adopt open banking faster
- Support tools that bring all accounts together in one view
- Enforce strong data protection rules to keep users safe

Other countries like the UK already use open banking frameworks to power smarter apps that help people manage money better. Nigeria has a chance to do the same—making financial life simpler and more connected for everyone.

Telcos and streamers: From data vendors to financial allies

Telecom companies are in a unique position to influence financial habits. **46.1% of respondents list airtime/data as a monthly expense,** second only to food. That's not just a cost burden—it's a direct line into users' financial behavior.

MTN already dominates the market with 79.6% usage. This gives them—and other telcos—a chance to go beyond selling data.

They can:

- Introduce reward bundles that tie data use to savings milestones
- Partner with fintechs to offer micro-savings or credit products
- Structure broadband packages that appeal economically to home and business users

Streaming companies, meanwhile, face a more value-sensitive audience. With only 8.6% of surveyed Nigerians listing subscriptions as a spending category, paid entertainment competes with pressing essentials.

To grow, platforms could explore:

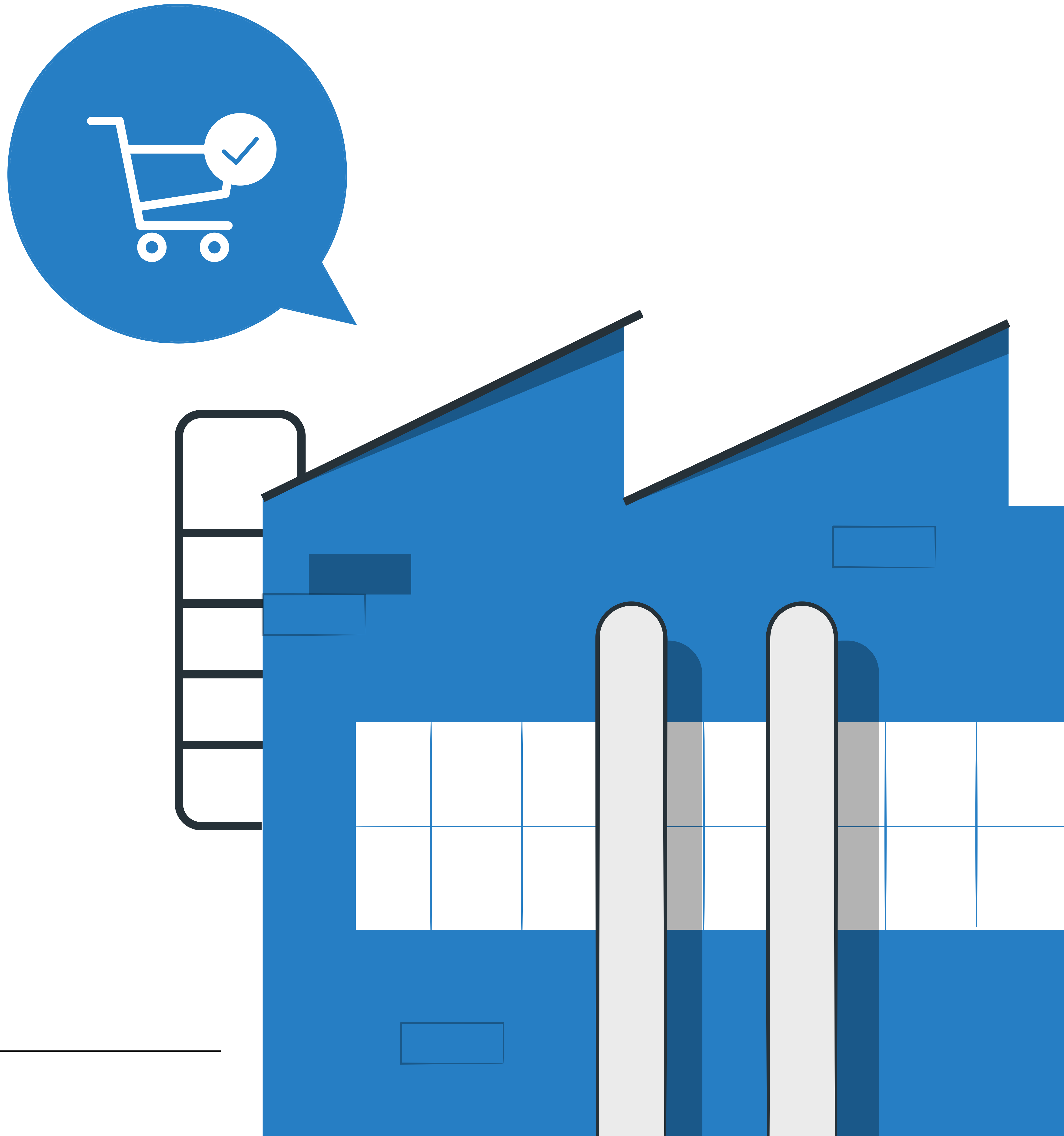
- Data-efficient plans or bundling with telcos
- Tiered pricing for mobile-first users
- Free basic tiers with upsells

For both telecom and streaming providers, reducing the **"cost-to-access"** barrier—whether through smarter bundling, targeted rewards, or budget-friendly tiers—can drive both adoption and retention.

Retailers: Turning daily spenders into loyal savers

Retailers—both online and offline—have a unique view into how young Nigerians spend. The data shows that the top spending categories are **food, airtime/data (46.1%), transportation (36.8%),** and **family support (27.2%).** These are core needs, not luxuries. That means most retail purchases are functional, not aspirational.

To stay relevant in this environment, retailers must respond to the realities of low-margin, high-frequency spending. Essentials win attention, but price sensitivity is high.



Retailers can take the lead by:

Offering value-focused pricing: Bundle core products (e.g. groceries, transport cards, airtime vouchers) at a discount to help customers save on everyday spending.

Introducing flexible payments: Let customers split payments or use pay-small-small models for larger purchases.

Linking to fintech saving tools: Help customers set savings goals within their apps or yours—e.g.

"**Save ₦500** weekly for that blender" or "**Lock ₦100 daily** towards your next school run."

These small changes help people feel in control of their spending—which builds loyalty.

Impulse spending is also a key behavioral pattern. 40.6% of unplanned purchases are triggered by sales or discounts, making urgency-based promotions a powerful lever. But in a low-income, high-awareness market, retailers need to balance this with trust. If discounts feel manipulative, they lose effectiveness over time. That's why transparency matters. Retailers should consider:

- **Showing simple price breakdowns**: Help customers understand value for money.
- **Integrating expense summaries:** Let users see how much they've spent in-app this week or month.
- **Rewarding consistency:** Give small benefits for sticking to budgets or saving towards planned purchases.

In a tough economy, retailers who help shoppers spend smarter—not just spend more—will stand out. And by embedding financial awareness into the retail experience, they can move from being just a place to shop to a partner in everyday survival.

Summary of key insights

Money management is reactive, not planned.

Most people focus on short-term survival. Emergencies, sales, and unexpected needs drive behavior more than structured planning

There's a strong desire for better tools.

Respondents want help saving automatically, tracking expenses, and seeing all financial activity in one place—clear signals for product builders.

Mobile-first is the norm.

Young, tech-savvy users are already using mobile money apps like Opay and Palmpay. Speed, low data usage, and reliability are key to growth.

Open ecosystems are the future.

The majority want unified dashboards, but open banking isn't mainstream yet. Cross-platform access and partnerships (banks, fintechs, retailers) are critical to unlocking full visibility and utility.

Final thoughts and future research

This report highlights the tension between financial aspiration and economic reality in Nigeria. Young people want to save, budget, and plan—but they're held back by unstable income, rising costs, and limited access to tools that truly meet their needs.

There's clear momentum around digital finance, but usage is still shallow. People use apps, but not always intentionally. They save, but inconsistently. They budget, but often fall short. This is where both innovation and education can play a bigger role.

Future research can go deeper into what drives these behaviors:

- How do gender, education level, or rural vs. urban location change financial habits?
- What triggers trust in a financial tool—and what breaks it?
- How can we design tools that work for the financially anxious, not just the financially savvy?

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About the authors

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Mo Shehu is the CEO of Column, a B2B communications and research firm based in the UK. He holds a PhD in Informatics and has worked across academia, media, tech, and public affairs over more than a decade—leading research, content strategy, and digital visibility projects for founders, startups, and institutions.

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At Column, he spearheads product and design initiatives that turn complex ideas into clear, functional solutions. This report was driven by his curiosity about how Nigerians actually behave with money—and how good design can nudge better habits.

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